

National Curriculum Framework 2023

Ministry of Education and Skills Development (MoESD) | Circular MoESD/EDU/2023/14
(Consolidated) | Effective 1 April 2023 | Supersedes Framework 2022 where inconsistent

Preamble

This Framework establishes national expectations for curriculum structure, pedagogy, assessment alignment, and monitoring. It must be read with the Student Data Privacy Policy (MoESD/EDU/2024/09), Teacher Training & Certification Guidelines (MoESD/EDU/2024/11), and technical reports from National Institute for Education Assessment (NIEA) including RLOS Phase II. States retain authority over textbook selection within competency bands defined herein.

Part I — General Provisions

Clause 1.1 — Purpose and Scope

- 1.1.1 The Framework applies to all recognized schools delivering programs from Foundational Stage through Secondary Stage as defined in Clause 2.
- 1.1.2 Vocational integrative tracks may adopt alternate hour allocations subject to MoESD notification.

Clause 1.2 — Guiding Principles

Curriculum design shall prioritize foundational literacy and numeracy through Grade 5, experiential science and integrated STEM in middle stages, and multidisciplinary critical thinking in secondary years. Digital fluency is mandatory but subordinate to offline pedagogical relationships except where DLI schedules are formally adopted.

Part II — Stage-wise Competency Architecture

Clause 2.1 — Foundational Stage (Ages 3–8)

- 2.1.1 Oral language richness, print awareness, and number sense shall constitute no less than 60% of instructional time.
- 2.1.2 Assessment for this stage shall use LOI-compatible instruments; high-stakes examinations are prohibited.

Clause 2.2 — Middle Stage (Grades 6–8)

- 2.2.1 Integrated STEM pathways should replace siloed science introductions where teacher supply permits (see STEM evaluation NIEA/TR/2024/STEM-03).
- 2.2.2 States invoking Framework 2022 science strands during transition must document fidelity in quarterly reports.

Part III — Assessment and Monitoring

Clause 9.7 — Promotion and Competency Bands

Competency bands describe learning progress; they shall not automatically determine grade promotion unless state legislation explicitly links them. Confusion with LOI cut scores has caused wrongful retention pilots in two districts (corrected by MoESD advisory 2023/09).

Clause 11.3 — Disaster and Exception Reporting

11.3.1 Districts under notified disaster may delay LOI reporting by one academic term with retroactive documentation.

11.3.2 Abuse of exception status triggers audit under Clause 18.2 penalties.

Reporting item	Frequency	Responsible officer	Destination
LOI district dashboard	Termly	District Assessment Cell	SDP → NIEA
STEM lab utilization	Quarterly	Lab in-charge	State portal
NCF fidelity sample	Annual	Inspectorate	MoESD
Stakeholder council minutes	Biannual	School Management Committee	Public notice board

Implementation Phases and Reporting Timelines

Phase	Window	Reporting obligation
Phase 0 — Alignment audit	Months 1–6	State gap analysis to MoESD
Phase 1 — Pilot districts	Months 7–18	Quarterly LOI-aligned reports
Phase 2 — Statewide rollout	Months 19–36	Annual compliance certification
Phase 3 — Independent review	Month 37+	NIEA external validation

Definitions and Interpretation

Unless context requires otherwise, capitalized terms match usage in cross-referenced MoESD circulars. Where two documents define the same term differently, the more specific document controls for that domain (e.g., 'baseline' in assessment reports vs. enrollment data policy).

Competency Band

A developmental descriptor grouping skills and dispositions; not equivalent to grade-level promotion gates unless state rules explicitly link them (see Clause 9.7).

Framework 2022

The predecessor curricular reference retained in STEM pathways until full NCF 2023 substitution; STEM evaluation reports may cite Framework 2022 for science strands only.

LOI (Learning Outcome Index)

National metric administered by National Institute for Education Assessment (NIEA); distinct from school-leaving examination scores.

Monitoring Schedule

Calendar of reporting obligations; exceptions for disaster-affected districts per Clause 11.3.

Stakeholder Council

Body comprising parents, teachers, industry, and civil society with consultative—not veto—authority.

Part IV — Stakeholder Responsibilities

Clause 14 — MoESD

14.1 Maintain national competency lexicon and LOI equating studies.

Clause 15 — State Education Boards

15.1 Align textbooks to competency bands within 24 months of Framework publication.

15.2 Operate TTC networks per Teacher Training Guidelines.

Clause 16 — Schools

16.1 Publish annual implementation plan including DLI and library metrics.

Part V — Penalties and Enforcement

Clause 18.2 — Administrative Penalties

Systematic misreporting of monitoring data may result in withholding of central grants, directed audits, and personal accountability notices for certifying officers. Criminal provisions apply only where fraud is established under applicable law—not for pedagogical shortfalls alone.

Violation class	First offense	Repeat offense
Late reporting (<30 days)	Written warning	Grant hold 5%
Falsified LOI samples	Audit + corrective plan	Grant hold 15%
Unauthorized data sharing	Referral to privacy policy	License suspension

Compliance Notes for Implementing Officers

Implementing officers must retain evidence of adherence for seven years or until superseded by amendment, whichever is longer. Electronic records stored on the SDP must use role-based access controls described in the Student Data Privacy Policy. Failure to document phase completion constitutes a reportable incident under Clause 18.4 where systemic patterns emerge.

Waivers may be granted only through the hierarchical approval workflow: School Head → District Education Officer → State Commissioner → MoESD Joint Secretary (Assessment & Policy). Emergency waivers during notified disasters follow expedited 72-hour retroactive approval rules in Annexure E.

Annexure A — Competency Band Exemplars (Language)

Band L-3: Learner retells grade-appropriate narrative with inference questions (see RLOS ORF benchmarks).

Annexure B — Cross-References

- Student Data Privacy Policy — SDP fields for monitoring uploads
- Teacher Training Guidelines — certification definitions
- RLOS Phase II — empirical LOI gains and equity analysis
- Online Education Effectiveness — DLI dosage evidence

Supplemental Provisions — SP

The following clauses elaborate enforcement mechanics omitted from the primary parts due to length constraints. They are binding unless explicitly marked advisory. Cross-references to NIEA technical reports are illustrative, not incorporative by reference, except where MoESD circulars state otherwise.

SP.1 Implementing authorities shall document adherence to data minimization, pedagogical time allocations, and reporting timelines specified in the master schedule. Sub-clause SP.1.1 clarifies that waivers require written justification within ten working days of the triggering event. Sub-clause SP.1.2 requires publication on the school notice board and SDP parent portal where operational.

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Worked Examples

Example 1: A district delays LOI reporting citing floods. The District Education Officer files Form EX-11 within 15 days, MoESD grants one-term extension, and NIEA marks those schools as non-comparable in public dashboards until wave completion.

Example 2: A school uploads STEM videos to SDP portfolios without parental opt-in. The DPO orders deletion within 72 hours; repeated offense escalates under privacy policy Article 12.

Example 3: A teacher with provisional certification leads DLI sessions. The school must either assign a micro-credential holder as lead or suspend DLI until Phase IV readiness under TTC Guidelines.

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Master Reporting Calendar (Excerpt)

Board	Phase	Deadline
SEB-KA	Phase 0	Due 2023-Q1
SEB-KA	Phase 0	Due 2023-Q2
SEB-KA	Phase 0	Due 2023-Q3
SEB-KA	Phase 0	Due 2023-Q4
SEB-KA	Phase 1	Due 2024-Q1
SEB-KA	Phase 1	Due 2024-Q2
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SEB-KA	Phase 1	Due 2024-Q4
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SEB-KA	Phase 2	Due 2025-Q4
SEB-KA	Phase 3	Due 2026-Q1
SEB-KA	Phase 3	Due 2026-Q2
SEB-KA	Phase 3	Due 2026-Q3
SEB-KA	Phase 3	Due 2026-Q4
SEB-MH	Phase 0	Due 2023-Q1
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SEB-MH	Phase 0	Due 2023-Q4
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Board	Phase	Deadline
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